



FINE DINING: Anar Patel (front) with volunteers at Seva Café

With Gandhi in Their Hearts

At this unique restaurant, diners get to decide how much to pay after being served by their city's rich

■ By Uday Mahurkar

Call it a unique exercise in Gandhian altruism or simply a restaurant with a difference. Seva Café, a 50-seat terrace restaurant in downtown Ahmedabad, is trying to become a synonym for public service. After having dinner here one doesn't pay a bill but donates money as per their wish. Half of over a dozen-odd people one sees managing the restaurant every evening are, in fact, volunteers, often belonging to rich families, and come by turns to offer their voluntary services, including jobs like cleaning utensils.

Says Anar Patel of NGO Gramshree, who along with her husband Jayesh Patel and a clutch of other Gandhian NGOs mooted the concept three years ago: "This restaurant aims at connecting hearts". Says Jayesh: "Seva Café doesn't run on bill but on *dil* (heart). Our profit doesn't weigh in money. It weighs in the number of hearts it is able to win." The proceeds from the restaurant are routed in turns to various social bodies for different public service projects.

The objective of opening the evening restaurant is to inculcate a spirit of social service in the common man,



particularly the materialistic upper strata of society. Seva Café wants to offer quality food along with good service. It has a rotating menu that keeps changing. Different cuisines are offered at least once a week with the number of dishes on each day restricted to six in all. As one finishes dinner here, he is handed over an envelope

in which he can put the amount he wishes to donate before dropping it into a box.

Every year around 400 new people offer their voluntary services at Seva Café. Some like Lopaben Shah, wife of a city-based businessman, have got addicted to the concept of this restaurant. Shah not only dines regularly at the restaurant but has also offered her voluntary services here in many capacities. She has washed utensils here and has cooked too. Same is true of Azaan Khan, a student who comes from a wealthy family. Says Shah: "For me Seva Café is like heaven. It gives the pleasure of eating as well as serving at the human level. It's a magnificent thought that connects people with people."

Indeed, this restaurant goes a long way in re-defining the fine-dining experience. ■